

The Multiplicity of Meaning, chapter 1

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28th March 2025

1 Introduction

Plural Signification Almost always, when x bears an intentional relation¹ to y , x bears that relation to many other entities similar to y .

2 Intuitions

Some plausible cases where words express several fairly similar properties:

Are Jaffa Cakes <i>biscuits</i> ? ²	Are hamburgers <i>sandwiches</i> ?
Is chilli <i>soup</i> ? ³	Are muffins <i>cakes</i> ?
Is herbal tea <i>tea</i> ?	Is a cheese course <i>dessert</i> ?
Are cucumbers <i>fruit</i> ?	Are cucumbers <i>vegetables</i> ?
Is oat milk <i>milk</i> ?	Are plants <i>creatures</i> ?
Are lynxes <i>cats</i> ?	Are human beings <i>animals</i> ?
Do octopuses have <i>legs</i> ?	Are sporks <i>spoons</i> ?
Are cardigans <i>sweaters</i> ?	Is paddling a canoe <i>rowing</i> it?
Are watercolours <i>drawings</i> ?	Is cardboard <i>paper</i> ?
Are iPads <i>computers</i> ?	Are most philosophers <i>writers</i> ?
Are APA comments <i>talks</i> ?	Are glasses <i>cups</i> ? ⁴
Are building societies <i>banks</i> ? ⁵	Are lake-edges <i>banks</i> ?

In each case, there are some “specialized” uses that assume a ‘yes’ answer, some that assume a ‘no’ answer, and some “indifferent” uses where the speaker isn’t disposed towards either.

- The different “specialized” uses refer to different properties; “indifferent” uses refer to all of them.
- Such examples suggests that many words express sufficiently many properties than it would make sense to try to list in a dictionary.
- Given this, it’s plausible that, e.g., ‘heap’ expresses a whole spectrum of properties—enough that any number between the minimal grain-counts for two of them is the minimal grain-count for a third.
- *Claim*: *being vague* is expressing multiple things; or, sufficiently many sufficiently similar things.

¹ ‘Semantic relations’ include speech act relations (*saying, asserting, telling, claiming, suggesting, whispering, ...*); mental relations (*knowing, believing, judging, hoping, being confident in, consciously entertaining*) and narrowly semantic relations (*expressing, meaning, denoting, referring to...*). Relations like *being the conjunction of everything asserted by* had better not count!

²The UK’s VAT tribunal says Jaffa Cakes aren’t biscuits: <https://www.gov.uk/hmrc-internal-manuals/vat-food/vfood6260>.

³For a thorough investigation of the question ‘What makes soup soup?’, see <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Y1HVTNxwt7w>.

⁴See Manley 2009.

⁵See Kearns and Magidor 2008.

Reminder: words like ‘express’, ‘say’, etc. are vague. I think that when I say, e.g., ‘Expressing is one-many’, I refer to many relations, and say something true of each of them.

3 *A suggestive argument*

Argument One

Since a single indifferent use can be correctly indirectly reported using several different non-indifferent uses of the speaker's words⁶, indifferent uses involve saying multiple things.

Unpromising response: We're taking liberties; the speech reports aren't literally true.

Workable response: Speech act verbs like 'say' vary with the other words: indifferent uses of 'There are cups' uniquely say₁ that there are cups₁ and uniquely say₂ that there are cups₂.

⁶ — There are clean cups in the dishwasher.

... — You said there were clean cups in the dishwasher, but you were wrong: in fact every cup in the house was dirty, so I decided to put have a glass of orange juice instead.

... — You said there were clean cups in the dishwasher, but you were wrong, so I took this one from the cupboard, and put orange juice in it.

4 *Objections*

Objection One

Pluralism about *expressing* conflicts with the Unique Disquotational Meaning Schema:

UDE 'A' uniquely expresses A.

Response: (i) The schema is inconsistent. (ii) It rules out the least controversial cases of ambiguity like that of 'tank'.

Objection Two

Pluralism about *expressing* conflicts with the Disquotational Truth Schema:

DT 'P' is true if and only if P.

Gloss: Whether a sentence is true depends on what it expresses, so if a sentence and its negation both express a mixture of truths and falsehoods, both or neither are true. DT rules this out.

Response: (i) The schema is inconsistent. (ii) The practice of applying 'true' to sentences is an unfortunate philosopher's invention.

Objection Three⁷

Pluralism about *saying* conflicts with the following principles about truth and falsity for utterances:

TDEF₁ An utterance is true iff it says something true.

Don't say this: 'There is no single thing that is the property of being a tank: there are only the properties of being a container-tank and being a vehicle-tank'.
Get used to this: 'There is a single thing that is the property of being a tank, and it's expressed by "tank", although it's not the only property expressed by "tank"'.
⁷ See Andjelkovic and Williamson 2000.

FDEF₁ An utterance is false iff it says something false.

Gloss: No utterance is both true or false. So by *TDEF₁* and *FDEF₁*, no utterance both says something true and says something false. But on the pluralist picture where utterances often say many things, that should be common.

Response: Ordinary ‘true’ and ‘false’ don’t apply to utterances either.⁸ But if one wants to introduce them as terms of art, it’s fine to break the symmetry between truth and falsity.⁹ Saying nothing false is a common, reasonable goal; saying nothing true is no-one’s goal.

Objection Four

Pluralism requires positing pervasive error in ordinary speeches¹⁰ involving counting the relata of semantic relations.

Response: Such speeches generally involve drastic contextual quantifier-domain restriction.

Objection Five

Monism about *context-relative expressing*¹¹ is needed in order to state explanatory generalisations connecting the semantic properties of complex expressions with the semantic properties of their constituents.

Explanandum: (1–3) express only necessary falsehoods, whereas (4) expresses both truths and falsehoods.¹²

- (1) Princeton is big and Princeton is not big.
- (2) Princeton is huge and Princeton is not huge.
- (3) Princeton is huge and Princeton is not big.
- (4) Princeton is big and Princeton is not huge.

The complete truth about which propositions ‘Princeton is big’ and ‘Princeton is huge’ *express* can’t explain this. But given monism about context-relative expressing, we can do so by saying that the proposition expressed by ‘Princeton is huge’ relative to any context entails the one expressed by ‘Princeton is big’ relative to that context.¹³

Response: theorise directly about a family of *co-expressing* relations, between n linguistic expressions and n entities of appropriate categories (relative to a language/linguistic community and, if you want, a context).¹⁴ Sample generalizations:

⁸ See Strawson 1950.

⁹ For example, by adopting

TDEF₂ An utterance is true iff everything it says is true.

or, better:

TDEF₃ An utterance is true iff it says something and everything it says is true.

¹⁰ ‘The only thing I said was that it was raining’; ‘I only told her three of the four things you told me’.

¹¹ *Context-relative expressing:* linguistic expression a expresses item x in the language of community z relative to context c , where contexts $\approx$ ⟨person, time, world⟩ triples.

¹² To accommodate the fact that one could utter (1–3) without saying anything false, perhaps better to say that they all express both truths and falsehoods, but (1–3) only *uniformly express* necessarily falsehoods whereas (4) uniformly expresses both truths and falsehoods. Let’s understand ‘express’ as ‘uniformly express’ throughout.

¹³ One might try to do the same work by relativizing not to contexts but things like *interpretations of the whole language* or *global assignment functions*. But these are metaphysically problematic.

¹⁴ *Expressing* is just the special case where $n = 1$.

- If sentences S_1, S_2, S_3 co-express p, q, r , and S_3 is the result of combining S_1 and S_2 with ‘and’, then $r = p \wedge q$.
- If name a , predicate F , and sentence S co-express x, Y, p , and S is the result of concatenating F to a , then $p = Yx$.

5 *What you assert versus what your sentence expresses*

Picture: the propositions expressed by a sentence in your context are all *available* to be asserted, but which ones you actually assert will depend on your purposes, which will in turn depend on how *plausible* the different propositions are in the light of your evidence.

6 *Is the view too friendly to non-disquotational speech reports?*

If Anna uttered ‘The number of guests was much less than 100’, it’s maybe a bit odd to say ‘Anna said that the number of guests was less than n ’ for any $n < 100$. This may seem surprising given pluralism. Shouldn’t I be able to know that for certain n , among the things Anna said was that the number of guests was less than n ?

Not obviously: pluralism is neutral about how often it happens that a single proposition is expressed by two distinct English sentences.

My favoured response to this sort of worry will appeal to the kind of ‘guise-sensitivity’ that makes ‘Anna said that Hesperus is bright’ odd when Anna uttered ‘Phosphorus is bright’, or ‘Anna said that she saw a female fox’ odd when Anna uttered ‘I saw a vixen’.

References

- Andjelkovic, Miroslava, and Williamson, Timothy (2000), ‘Truth, Falsity, and Borderline Cases’, *Philosophical Topics*, 28/n/a: 211–42.
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- Strawson, P. F. (1950), ‘Truth’, *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, 24 (supp.) 129–56.